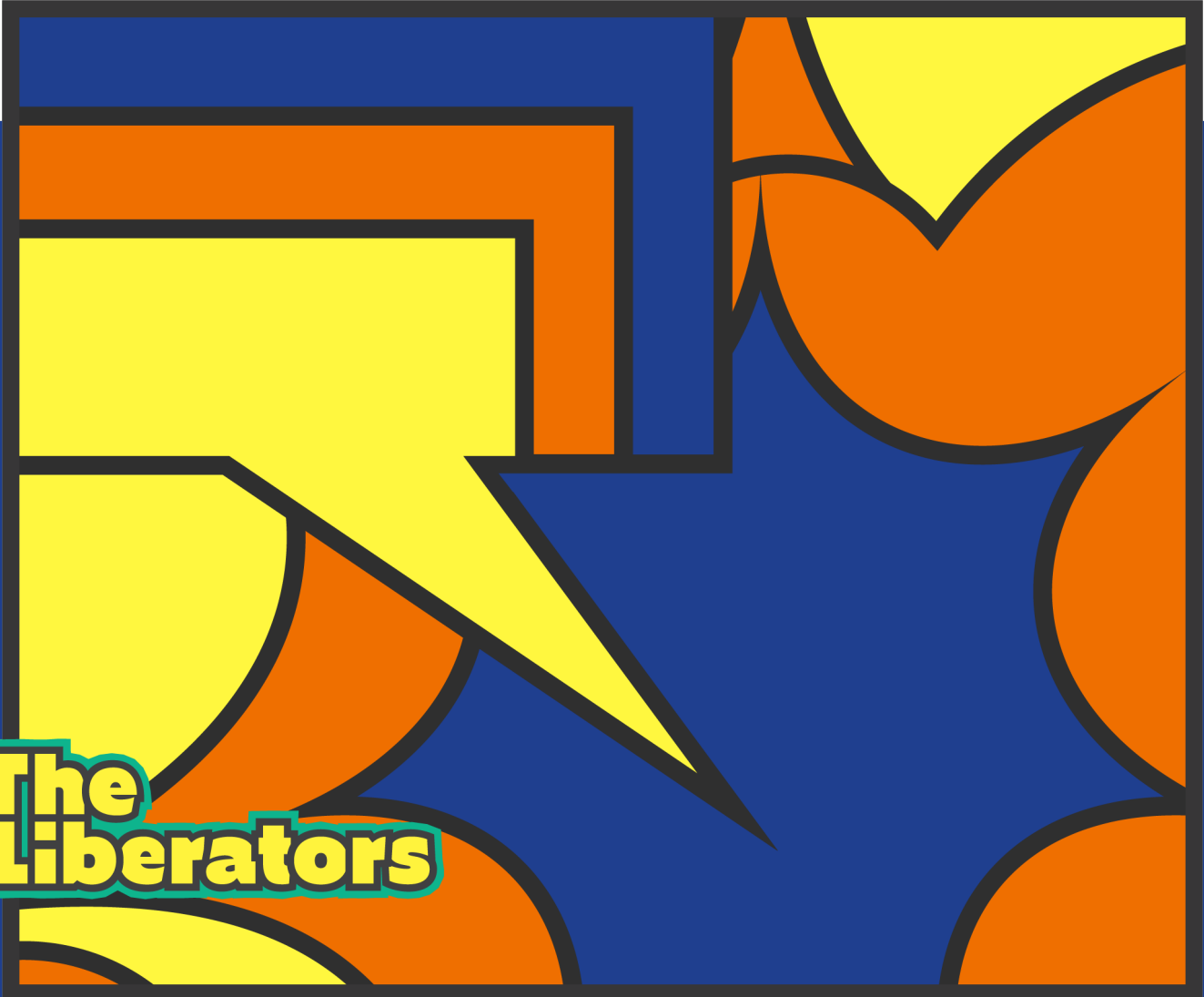


Use Ecocycle Planning To Make The State Of Your Product Transparent

A do-it-yourself workshop to make new and existing ideas for your product transparent, inspect what this means, and identify improvements to give product development a boost.



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

Whenever you're in the middle of developing a product, it's easy to lose sight of what really matters. Are we spending time on the features that provide the most value? Which features do we need to creatively reinvent or expand in order to move our product forward? What are things we should focus on in the upcoming period?

It's important to continuously discuss these questions together with your stakeholders. Especially, because due to the complex nature of software development, more is unknown than known. No matter how much time you spend with your stakeholders at the start, you'll always gain new ideas while developing the product. This goes for both the team *and* stakeholders. So it's important to have a close collaboration and share ideas, insights, and assumptions.

With this workshop, you make the current state of your product transparent, inspect what this means, and identify improvements to give product development a boost. Ideally, you run this workshop together with your stakeholders. For example, during the Sprint Review.

The exercise is built on the powerful Liberating Structure [Ecocycle Planning](#). Ecocycle Planning can look overwhelming, but just give it a try and let the structure do the heavy lifting.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
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Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Identify The Features Of Your Product

  20 min

Step 3: Make The Current State Of The Product Transparent

  40 min

Step 4: Inspect The State Of Your Product Together

  30 min

Step 5: Identify Improvements

  25 min

Step 6: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 120 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



Ecocycle Planning can look overwhelming, but just give it a try and let the structure do the heavy lifting.

Impact On Survival



Innovation is at the heart of product development. This workshop gives your team a boost to develop the features that matter to your users and stakeholders.



How To Prepare



Group Size

Ecocycle Planning can be done with one Scrum team, but also with many at the same time if they're working on the same product. This allows you to see patterns across teams.

Intended Audience

This string is designed for Scrum teams. We highly recommend that you include important stakeholders and users of the product as well. Our experience is that Ecocycle Planning is a great way for them to see where they can contribute to a team that is delivering value to them.

Virtual Delivery

We've successfully used this exercise with virtual teams. It does require preparation and the right tools. In our work, we purposefully follow the principles of [Liberating Structures](#) and break down interactions into smaller groups to allow *everyone* to contribute – and not just the loud voices and know-it-alls. If you are working with a group beyond five participants, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#).

In in-person exercises, we put the cards on a flat surface. In a virtual session, you can use a virtual whiteboard like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#) to provide a similar experience. You can set up your canvas as shown in the screenshot. If you have multiple groups, copy the canvas a couple of times so that each group has its own canvas and sets of events and activities.

Material

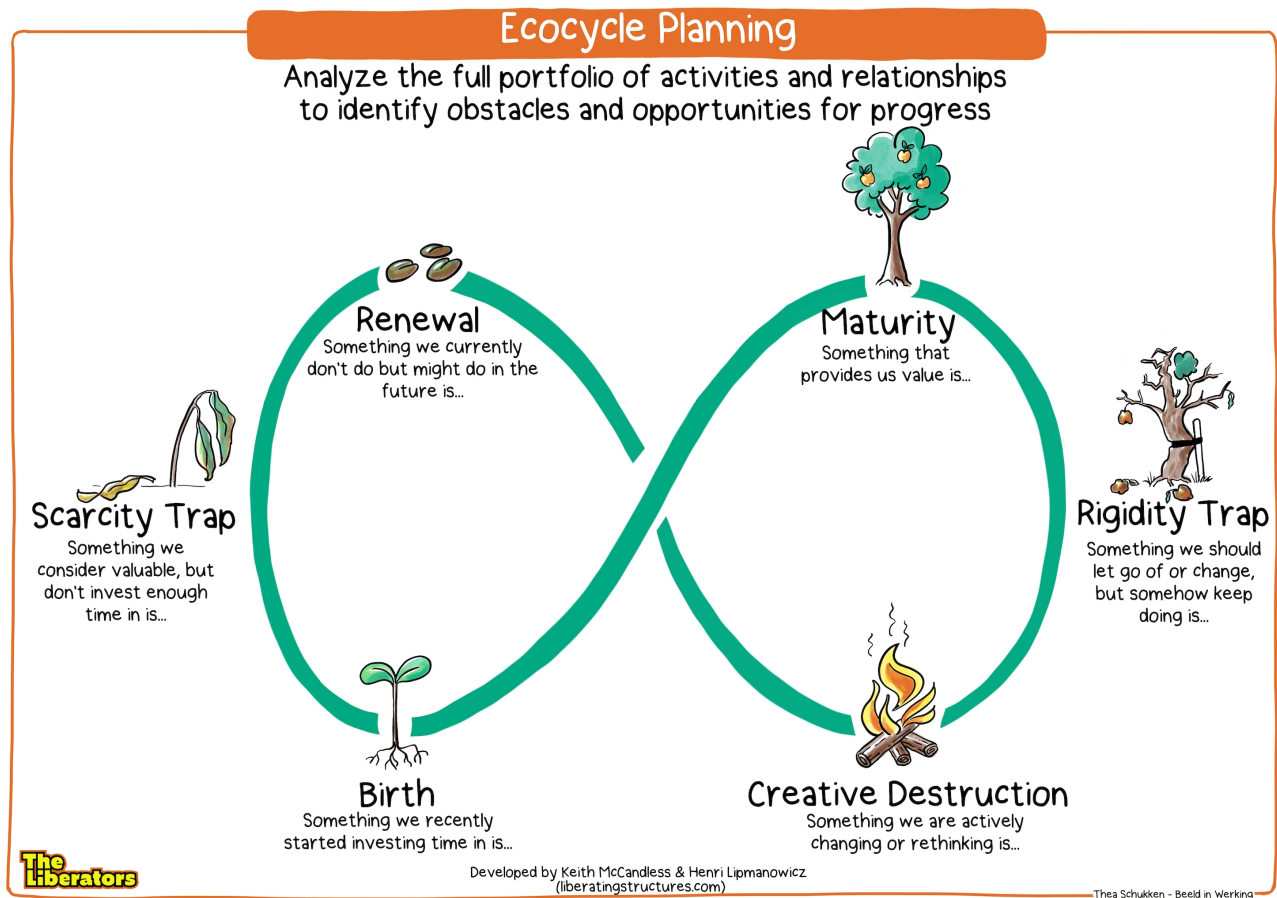
- Create one shared, empty canvas for Ecocycle Planning for each group of four in your total group
- Ideally, prepare one empty canvas for Ecocycle Planning for each person in your collaboration tool. If that isn't possible, participants can draw their Ecocycles on paper.
- Optionally, already create cards with the primary features of your product. Work together during the workshop to add features that are missing and include new ideas that aren't part of the product yet. By preparing these cards upfront, you save time during the workshop.
- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.

Resources

- Product: [Ecocycle Planning for Scrum Teams](#)
- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [Create focus with Ecocycle Planning](#)
- Blog post: [Help Development Teams Advance Their Technical Practices With Ecocycle Planning](#)



Ecocycle Planning: A Metaphor From Nature



Ecocycle Planning is part of the repertoire of Liberating Structures. Its purpose is to analyze the full portfolio of activities and identify obstacles and opportunities for progress in a markedly non-linear way. That makes it an excellent way to periodically reflect on your work together and to decide what to focus on next. It is based on the life cycle in nature.

The activities of your Scrum team can be plotted on an Ecocycle as follows:

- **Renewal** represents all the activities that you think would be useful to you as a team, but that you are not doing at the moment.
- **Birth** represents the activities that you have just started doing as a team, or that you've been investing in. Although they are not fully valuable yet, and probably take effort and discipline to do, they will become increasingly valuable as you keep doing them.
- **Maturity** represents the activities that are comfortable and valuable to you as a team. It doesn't take much effort or discipline to do them. It's become part of your rhythm as a Scrum Team.
- **Creative Destruction** represents the activities that have either lost their value to you as a team or need to be reinvented in order to become useful again. Perhaps by doing it in a different way or from a different perspective. Or do you want to stop doing them altogether?



All activities flow through the Ecocycle. But they can also get stuck. Activities that you know are important but are never invested in, get stuck in the Poverty/Scarcity Trap. Activities that you keep doing, but aren't really adding any value any longer, are in the Rigidity Trap. By plotting all your activities across the Ecocycle, you can identify patterns that tell you something about where you are as a team. Look for the following patterns in particular:

- A healthy Ecocycle is balanced. There is innovation taking place, as evidenced by activities on the left of the model, and there are activities that are mature, as evidenced by items on the right. Furthermore, teams are continuously reinventing how to do things and become better, as represented in what is in Creative Destruction.
- Activities that are in the Rigidity Trap and Creative Destruction are prime candidates for reinvention or even removal. Start there before adding new activities, as this creates space for something new.



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose, introduce the stakeholders, and start with the first structure. Superfast!



Step 2: Identify The Features Of Your Product

Before you start with Ecocycle Planning, you first need to identify the cards that you'll use for this exercise. Cards that contain the existing features of your product and potentially new features that you haven't built yet, but might develop at some point. If you want to shorten the timebox of this workshop, you can prepare these cards also upfront. Otherwise, use the Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) quickly collect ideas for all the product's (potential) features and write them on cards.

Invitation

"List the existing features of our product and complete the list with potential features we might develop in the future."

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask everyone to first individually and in silence reflect on the invitation and write down what comes to mind. If necessary, emphasize which product they'll need to create the cards for. This is in particular important if your team develops multiple products.
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs to share their ideas and build on them together. Help each other combine and expand their list with features. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3. **4 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and share their ideas, and how they built on them, again building on their ideas in a group of four. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms.
4. **8 min** Together, collect the lists with features of the product, remove duplicates, and write them on separate cards in a shared workspace.

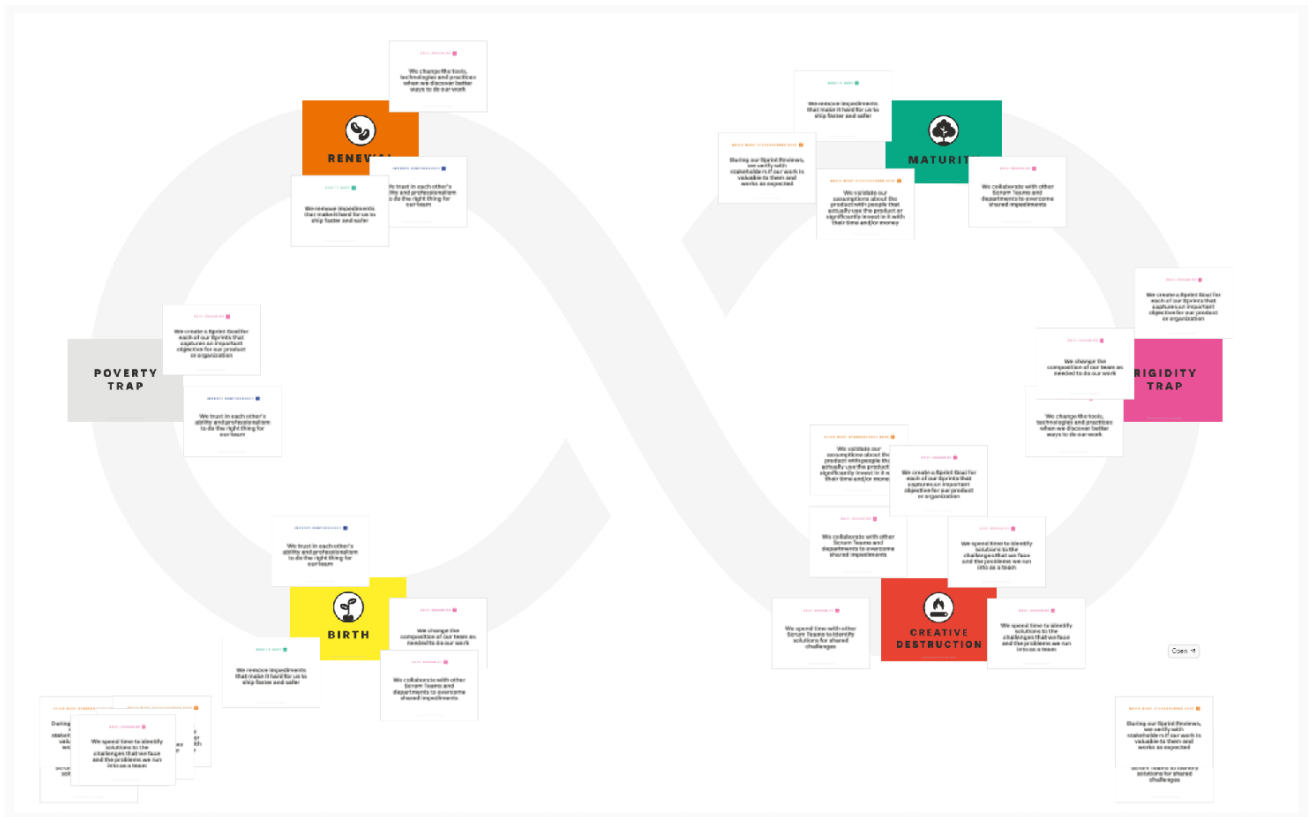
Our Findings

- The invitation in this workshop is focused on features. Optionally, you can also ask your team to create cards for technical debt, documentation, technical architecture, etc. This can be useful to make the state of your product even more transparent.
- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will. You can always do a second 1-2-4-ALL if you need to go deeper.
- Facilitate the silent self-reflection firmly, before the paired conversations, and invite everyone to write down their ideas. This allows participants to focus and make ideas tangible and specific.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with [1-2-4-ALL](#)

Step 3: Make The Current State Of The Product Transparent

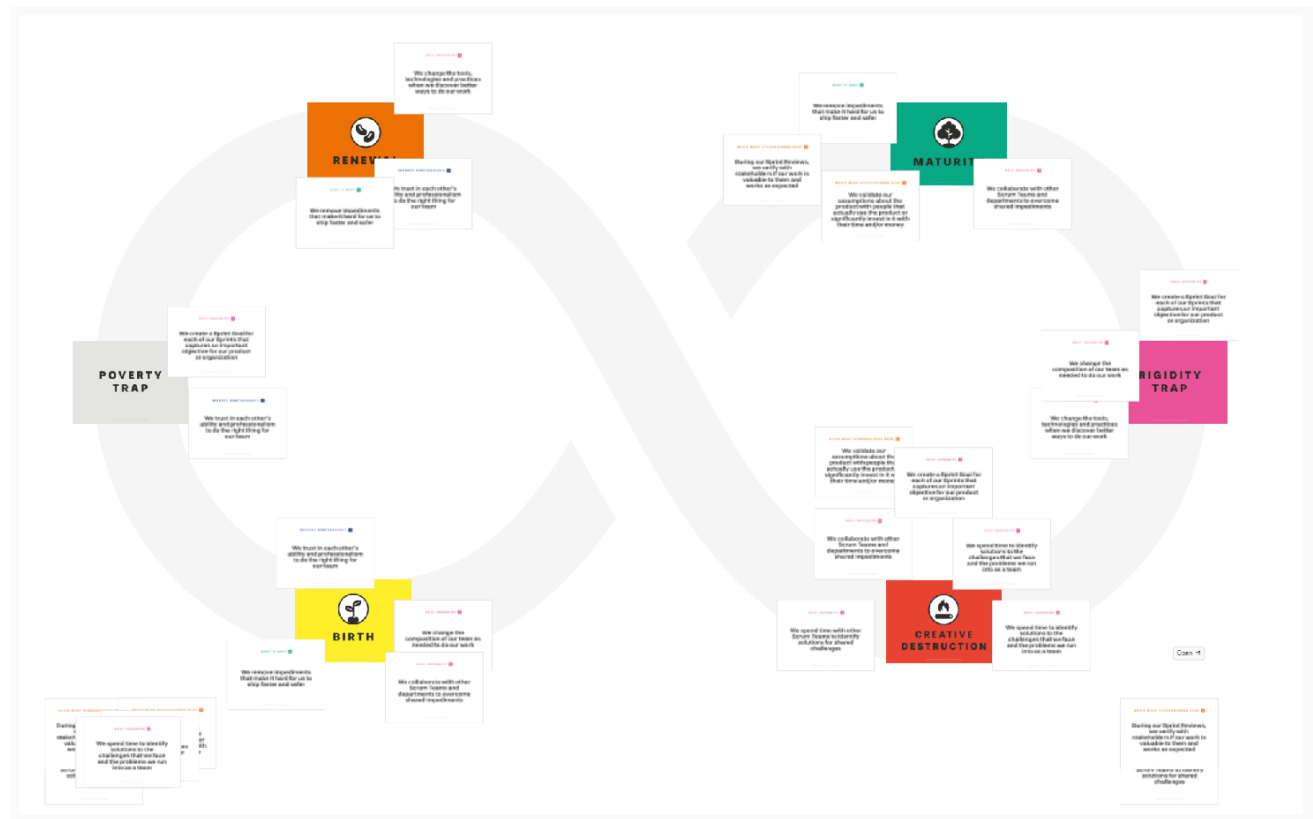


The first step with Ecocycle Planning is to create transparency about the state of the product at this moment. From there, you can start the inspection and adaptation.

Steps

1. **10 min** Introduce Ecocycle Planning. Explain the metaphor, the quadrants, and give some examples to help people understand it. It's okay if people don't get it right away; you often have to experience Ecocycle Planning several times to start seeing the possibilities. Briefly introduce the cards you've created in the previous round.
2. **10 min** Invite people to fill in an Ecocycle Planning individually. Either direct everyone to their individual empty canvas in your collaboration tool *or* ask people to draw an Ecocycle Planning on a piece of paper. Give them time to silently distribute the cards across their own Ecocycle based on where they think the activities are for the product. In the meantime, prepare breakouts for groups of four.
3. **5 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, introduce the shared and empty Ecocycle Canvas. Explain that people will be working together in the next steps to create a single Ecocycle Planning for their product that combines all their perspectives.
4. **15 min** Invite people into small groups and into their own breakouts. Ask "In your small group, share your individual Ecocycles. Where do you see similarities and differences in how you placed activities for your team?". Ask the small groups to place activities in the shared Ecocycle Planning where they think they are as a small group. Encourage people not to over-think it.

Step 4: Inspect The State Of Your Product Together



In the previous step, you created transparency around the current state of your product. You plotted all the existing features on the Ecocycle and added potential new features as well. The purpose of this step is to make sense of what this means for your team.

Steps

- 4 min** Invite people to step back and take in the patterns in the shared Ecocycle you created in the previous step. Ask them to focus on the items for which there is consensus. Ask "What does the placement of the items say about the state of our product? Where do you see connections between the items?". In the meantime, prepare breakouts for three rounds of different pairs.
- 15 min** Invite people into pairs and into their breakouts. Ask them to share the most salient patterns they notice (4 minutes). Repeat twice more in different pairs (8 minutes).
- 10 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, ask people to share the most salient patterns with the whole group. You can help draw out patterns by noticing where most cards of one color appear, whether or not the Ecocycle is balanced and which items appear in the traps.

Our Findings

- We purposefully use pairs, and not larger groups, to create safety for everyone to share their insights. Even in small groups, loud voices can drown out silent voices. By quickly rotating pairs, great insights and observations will spread through the group. If you really must do it with a larger group, use a [Conversation Cafe](#).
- Use "Creative Destruction" as the area where activities go that need to be creatively re-invented to be valuable again. An Ecocycle Planning with nothing in this area may be an indicator that double-loop learning – where existing structures are challenged – is limited in your team.



Step 5: Identify Improvements

In the previous steps, you created transparency together around your product. Then, you identified the impact together. In this final step, you help the team identify improvements.

Steps

1. **5 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to consider the following question for a few minutes: "Which features do we need to creatively reinvent or expand in order to move our product forward?". In the meantime, prepare breakouts for pairs and – for the step after that – breakouts with two pairs each.
2. **15 min** Invite people into pairs and into their breakouts to share their ideas and build on them **5 min**. Then, invite the pairs into new breakouts with another pair to share their ideas and build on them **10 min**.
3. **5 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, ask every group to share two or three of their most promising ideas. Capture these potential improvements as input for your Product Backlog or reorder the backlog immediately.
4. If you have the time and when the improvement ideas remain fairly abstract, you can use a Liberating Structure like "[Shift & Share](#)" to develop them further.

Our Findings

- You can also use [25/10 Crowd Sourcing](#) to quickly generate improvements ideas. David Heath created this [free virtual app](#) to do this online.
- When you are facing tough impediments, you can use Liberating Structures like [Discovery & Action Dialogue](#) and [Wise Crowds](#) to dig deeper.

Step 6: Closing

With this workshop, you've made the current state of your product transparent, inspected what this means, and identified improvements to give product development a boost.

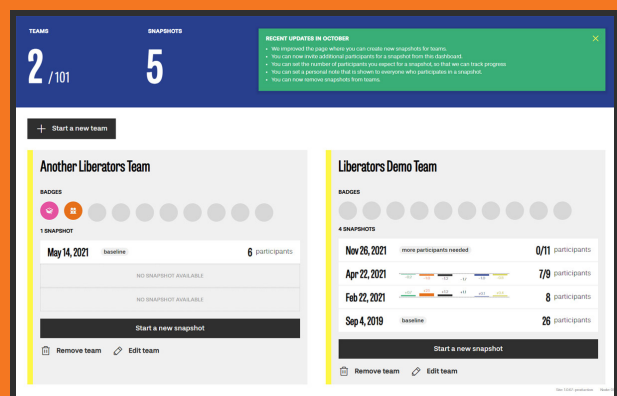
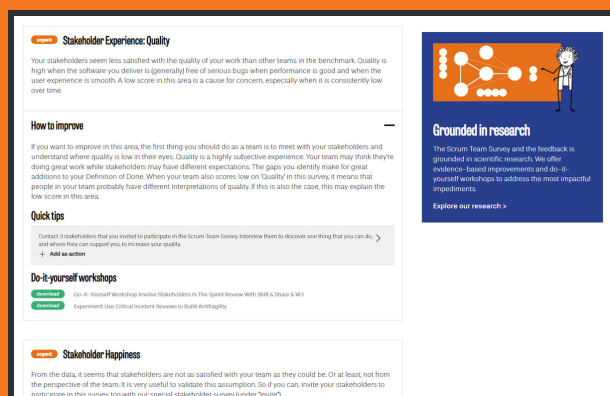
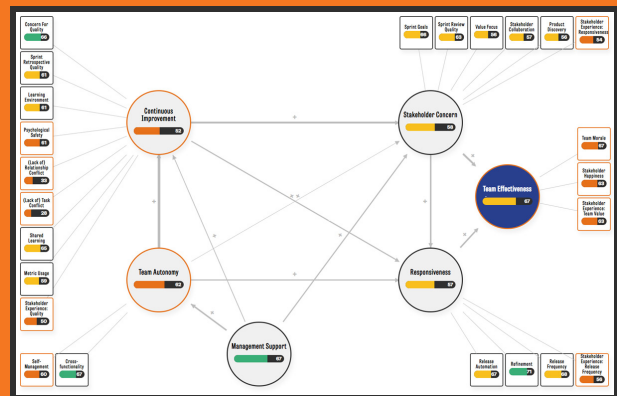
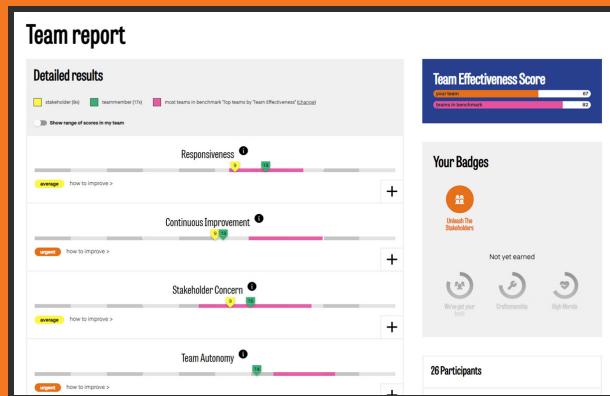
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



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